

Phenomenological Pragmatism, Naturalist Pragmatism, and Intentionality

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In the debate on the “Myth of the Mental” Hubert Dreyfus attacks John McDowell’s thesis (put forward in *Mind and World* and other writings) that experience is permeated by conceptuality and that this is what makes our “openness to the world” possible. Dreyfus argues that this is a highly intellectualist and constructed picture that ignores the “phenomenology of bodily coping.” In contrast to McDowell’s opinion, Dreyfus holds that it is the immersed and non-conceptual responding to affordances that opens up a world in the first place. One could characterize this position as a pragmatist approach to world-openness. Dreyfus not only evokes but explicitly cites the phenomenological traditions of Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty—the “existential phenomenologists”—who have emphasized that we are pre-reflectively “immersed” in a world: that Being-in-the-world is an essential characteristic of Dasein (Heidegger) and that the world is “there” before I think it—precisely because of my immemorial bodily engagement in it (Merleau-Ponty). But as the debate goes on, Dreyfus presents some revealing views on what he considers “mind” and “mindless coping” to be that do not go well with this tradition he claims to stand for at all. In the volume *Mind, Reason and Being-in-the-World: The McDowell-Dreyfus Debate* (ed. Scheer 2013), Dan Zahavi argues that Dreyfus’ understanding of “mindless coping” endorses a conception of mindedness which is considerably closer to McDowell than Dreyfus thinks and which rather resembles a “higher order theory” of consciousness; moreover, it involves a conception of self-consciousness as self-monitoring which is “far removed from the idea of an immersed, non-objectifying self-acquaintance that we find in phenomenology” (Zahavi 2013, 332). Zahavi suggests that Dreyfus might have fallen victim to a myth of its own, “namely the Myth of the Spectatorial Subject” (Zahavi 2013, 332).

Indeed, Dreyfus, quite bluntly, draws a dichotomous distinction between “phenomenologists” and “conceptualists,” which points to assumptions *allowing* for this dichotomy rather than to a phenomenological approach to the question shared by Husserl and Heidegger/Merleau-Ponty. In my paper, I want to challenge this reading of a “divide” in the phenomenological tradition between “mentalists”/Cartesians (Husserl) and “pragmatists” (Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty). I will argue that a correct understanding of the phenomenological core-notion of intentionality makes a simple divide between “theoretical mindedness” and “pragmatist bodiliness/existentiality” impossible. Beyond that, I want to claim that the question as to whether perceptual content or coping are either “conceptual” or “non-conceptual” misses the point about giving an intentional account of how our “grip on the world” is possible. For this, one neither needs to subscribe to a Kantian notion of transcendentalism (McDowell) nor to a rather crude dichotomy of monitoring mindedness and unconscious mindlessness in coping (Dreyfus). The general question that will guide my reflections is whether Dreyfus’ pragmatist reading of Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty isn’t

pushed so much in a naturalist direction that it actually prevents from conceiving the *phenomenological version of pragmatism* they develop, the roots of which can also be found already in Husserl. I elaborate on this argument concerning Dreyfus' take in the first and second sections and come back to what I consider to be the phenomenologists' counter-conception in the third section.

1. Misleading dichotomies and Dreyfus' naturalization of phenomenological pragmatism

Dreyfus' appreciation of what a phenomenological and a pragmatist approach can accomplish is considerably shaped by his critique of cognitivist models of the brain. And indeed, *What Computers Can't Do* (Dreyfus 1972) makes important arguments against the then-dominant AI model of conscious symbolic manipulation, claiming that human expertise and intelligence primarily builds on unconscious instincts that can never be captured in formal rules. Many years later, in his 2005 APA Presidential Address, which started the debate on the "Myth of the Mental" with John McDowell, Dreyfus still emphasizes the importance of this path for him. Notwithstanding its merits, I would like to question here if this framework has not decisively flawed Dreyfus' picture of the phenomenological tradition. On the one hand, he maps the dichotomy of cognitivist, algorithmic-vs.-embodied-brain models in terms of the "Cartesian Husserl" vs. the "existentialist phenomenologists." This goes as far as associating Husserl's phenomenology with the "frame problem,"¹ suggesting that Husserl even had a terminology of "frames" (Dreyfus 2005, 48), which, concerning the textual basis, is a rather surprising claim (Dreyfus must mean Husserl's term of "horizon" which, however, is a totally different concept, to which I will return later).

On the other hand, it seems sometimes that Dreyfus is just looking for an *alternative model of the brain* (like the "ambient optic array" by Gibson he mentions [Dreyfus 2005, 54]), where he finds the phenomenological-existential approaches to provide promising leads. This not only misses out on the radically different ontological projects that Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty propose: What they do captures existence and its bodily and temporal movement as the primary ontological event from which everything else gains its meaning. To re-formulate this again in a language of brain functions or models—where we "always already" know where to locate this no-longer-so-primary event—risks a regress into an ontology of the present-at-hand. Furthermore, Dreyfus' approach also leads to quite a different understanding of the pragmatist elements in the phenomenological descriptions. In the following, I would like to show that what Dreyfus is after, in the end results in something that comes close to a version of "naturalist pragmatism," whereas what the phenomenologists are after are pragmatist elements that resist naturalization. This is so, precisely because the existential phenomenological approaches *emerge from a conception of intentionality and consciousness similar to how Husserl formulates it*—even if they thoroughly transform and reformulate our intentional engagement in and with the world, thereby also strengthening the "pragmatist" elements. But this has to be read as a further development and not as a change of paradigm. Dreyfus' program, by contrast, presents two alternatives, neither of which I think are at the heart of either Heidegger's or Merleau-Ponty's respective phenomenological projects: namely, either mindless, blind, instinctive coping or mindful, objectifying, reason-giving

¹A very short description of this problem is given by Dreyfus himself: "[If] the computer has a representation of the current state of the world and something changes, how does the computer determine which of the represented facts stay the same, and which representations have to be updated?" (Dreyfus 2005, 48)

detachedness. Since each of these dichotomous pictures corresponds to certain models of the brain, they keep being tied to this paradigm of thought.

To illustrate this with a few quotes, let us take a short look at Dreyfus' picture of our "Being-in-the-world," which he primarily understands as "mindless coping," in our everyday occupations (like walking, cooking, running to the streetcar etc.) as well as in "expert coping" (like playing chess, baseball, music etc. on a professional level). The picture we get is that our body somehow operates in a mindless, subjectless, quasi-automatic darkness of instincts by which a "world," conforming to our systems and its needs, is "opened":

"We need to consider the possibility that embodied beings like us take as input energy from the physical universe and process it in such a way as to open them to a world organized in terms of their needs, interests, and bodily capacities without their minds needing to impose a meaning on a meaningless Given, as Minsky's frames require, nor their brains converting the stimulus input into reflex responses, as in Brooks's animats." (Dreyfus 2005, 49)

This corresponds to what is claimed in the introduction to *Being-in-the-World* (Dreyfus 1991), giving us a good example of how Dreyfus gradually naturalizes Heidegger's fundamental ontological investigation:

"Heidegger points out how background practices function in every aspect of our lives: encountering objects and people, using language, doing science, etc. But he can only *point out* the background practices and how they work to people who already share them—who, as he would say, dwell in them. He cannot *spell out* these practices in so definite and context-free a way that they could be communicated to any rational being or represented in a computer." (Dreyfus 1991, 4)

Hence, according to Dreyfus, Heidegger's approach makes clear that a model of applying rules with algorithms will never succeed in explaining how something can become relevant for us. The background of the "relevant world" instead emerges by executing a practice by which we somehow grasp the meaning of objects and surroundings. Although Dreyfus, in his Heidegger-interpretation, seeks to show that that "skillful coping," or the "know how" that we have while executing certain practices is not reducible either to mental states ("mind-talk"), nor to the brain processes ("brain-talk"), I nevertheless think that he ultimately takes Heidegger's analyses into a naturalist direction and gets stuck in the divide he himself wanted to avoid. This is precisely rooted in the dichotomic picture of "mindless coping" vs. "detached reflection" that ultimately goes back to two different models of the brain—which is where the nearly unavoidable naturalization comes in. So what Dreyfus presents us with in the end is that the background of the "relevant world" is "processed" without us ever being able to live through it, and as such this simply seems to be a product of our embodied brain.

This account directly flies in the face of what Heidegger *and* Husserl regard the phenomenological method to investigate, namely lived experiences, something we *live through* (which is not at all to be equated hastily with objectifying and theoretical acts). This approach has also been called an investigation of the "first-person perspective": It investigates only that which is consciously given to me, what I live through. My "ganglion cells," as Husserl puts it, thus do not belong to the phenomenological phenomenon because they are not given to me when I, for example, see a chair—although they might somehow

“cause” its perception (cf. Husserl 1952, 231). But this causal relation is a non-conscious and “blind” relation and can therefore never explain what my conscious experience of the chair, its “thereness” or “environmental presence” for me, is essentially about. Heidegger argues exactly the same way as Husserl that there might be a lot going on in the brain but that this simply does not belong to the phenomenological phenomenon that is to be analyzed (cf. Heidegger 2002, 44-45); and that only this, in the end, can be the real key to gain a genuine understanding of “how Dasein is its there.” Zahavi (2013, 322) is therefore right to wonder whether Dreyfus’ understanding of phenomenology is not instead that of Daniel Dennett’s “heterophenomenology,” which employs a third-person standard scientific approach to consciousness—instead of trying to explicate from within what this dimension is about. And Zahavi is also right in his correction that “our experiential life is not a question of non-conscious automaticity, rather qua experiential life it is precisely self-disclosing. This first-personal self-disclosure is immediate, nonobservational, noninferential and nonobjectifying” (Zahavi 2013, 331). I do not have to repeat these clearly made points about subjectivity, self-awareness, and lived experience in the phenomenological tradition here. Rather, let me just contrast two paradigmatic quotes by Dreyfus and Heidegger that show how much the former has pushed the latter’s existential analyses of Dasein’s immersion in the world into a naturalist direction:

“The copier does not need to be aware of himself even in some minimal way but only needs to be capable of entering a monitoring stance if the brain, which is comparing current performance with how things went in the past, sends an alarm signal that something is going wrong. Then one becomes attentive to one’s performance and one is solicited by the situation to make appropriate adjustments.” (Dreyfus 2007b, 374)

We have an agent here, “the brain,” which somehow “detects” that something is “going wrong”—without any form of being conscious or aware, to be sure. Heidegger’s famous example of hammering, which, as long as it goes well, does not have any object present (cf. Heidegger 1967/1962, §15), is thus thoroughly transposed into naturalist brain-language. Interestingly, Heidegger *also phenomenologically* claims the opposite of Dreyfus concerning “mindlessness” and “subjectlessness,” as can be gathered from his analyses in *Basic Problems of Phenomenology* (Heidegger 1975/1988, §15) and in *Towards the Definition of Philosophy* (Heidegger 1999/2000, §15): “The ‘it worlds’ [...] is experienced [*erlebt*] as ‘worlding.’” (Heidegger 2000, 79; Heidegger 1999, 94). With “it worlds,” or “*welten*” Heidegger means exactly the unthematic background of involvement and significance (cf. Heidegger 1967/1962, §18), and thus, what Dreyfus characterizes as non-conscious, mindless, and subjectless. But according to Heidegger, self-awareness is not lacking in this non-theoretical mode. On the contrary, Heidegger regards the involvement of an experiencing self in “worlding” even as more characteristic than is the case for theoretical acts:

“In this experiencing, in this living-towards, there is something of me: my ‘I’ goes out beyond itself and resonates with this seeing [...] [O]nly through the co-according of one’s own *I* does it [Dasein, S.L.] experience something environmental, where we can say that ‘it worlds.’ Wherever and whenever ‘it worlds’ for me, *I* am somehow there.” (Heidegger 2000, 62; trans. mod.)

Dreyfus seems to be aware of this outright contradiction, conceding to McDowell in a footnote that McDowell might be closer to Heidegger than he himself is, regarding this point

(McDowell claims the pervasiveness of something like a transcendental I in all experience, which, however, as I see it, is also not what Heidegger's experiential account is about). In any case, Dreyfus at least remains consistent regarding his commitment to neurological research. If it is not Heidegger who can comply with it, he finds his backup in his other preferred existential phenomenologist, Maurice Merleau-Ponty: "I'm siding with Merleau-Ponty and current neurological models of skilled action, (such as actor-critic reinforcement learning models), which claim that consciousness is only called into action once the brain has detected something going wrong." (Dreyfus 2007b, 377) I am quite convinced that Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology also does not support claims like these (Dreyfus does not give us any specific quote here as to his point of reference in Merleau-Ponty's work), but I will have to limit myself to some comments on this at the very end of the paper.

Yet, my point is not that it is per se bad to work with neuroscience to understand human intelligence and expertise. Certainly, this is a perfectly legitimate approach. But the question is: What is Dreyfus actually investigating with his phenomenology? Is he interested in how the brain really works (as an embodied brain, not as an algorithmic rule-applier) or in how "Dasein is its 'there'" (Heidegger 1962, 178)? I doubt that the one can easily be equated with the other. And if so, one would still have to spell out how. The difficulties that I see lie mainly in two factors. First, existence is something *I live through* and not something that my brain "does" for me. Phenomenology precisely wants to describe what this first-personal actualization amounts to and shows that it involves moments of passivity (which is experienced passivity!), of immersion, of temporal self-projection and of bodily orientedness. All of these basic features of existence are forms of *concomitant and equiprimordial awareness of self and world*, which is what the notion of intentionality is essentially about. But phenomenologists also show that existence just as much involves active stances, reflection, and predication. Yet, these capacities are not conceived of as a sudden detachedness that loses touch with everything, but as *one of the possible comportments of Being-in-and-toward-the-world, which is founded in more passive and bodily forms of intentionality*.² A model of the brain which is necessarily third-person in nature, no matter if it is rather built on "cognitivist" mindsets, on work with algorithmic structures, or rather on "pragmatist" mindsets, on work with "neural nets" and "optic arrays" (Dreyfus 2005, 54; 58), loses exactly this dimension of describing our Being-in-the-world as experienced in the first person.

Second: I have already mentioned that both Heidegger's and Merleau-Ponty's approaches involve ontological claims as well as transcendental ones that rule out an unproblematic shift between phenomenon-talk and brain-talk.³ Their demonstrations of a primary sphere where all possible meaning-formations emerge cannot be equated with what the brain "does" so simply. Finally, and more specifically, concerning the project of this volume: I have my doubts if the pragmatist elements that Dreyfus sees in Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty are rightly apprehended if they are pushed so strongly in a naturalist direction as we have seen above. Instead, I see the pragmatist elements in Heidegger, Merleau-Ponty, and partly also the late Husserl, rather point in the direction of a pragmatist version of intentional immersion: By this I mean a passive and bodily self-awareness in practices that is at the same time an *experienced* openness to the world. In the following section, I will focus on a special

² As Witold Plotka (xxxx) shows in the respective chapter of this volume, this is exactly the position of Husserl in *Experience and Judgment*.

³ Having said that, Dreyfus does not even seem to claim a parallelism between mental states and states of the brain, since his "phenomenological sphere" is partly non-experiential and thus only to be accessed by third-personal brain-language.

stage in this world-openness, one which presents problems to Dreyfus' conception: the transition from the pre-predicative to the predicative. I would like to show that a phenomenological understanding of pragmatist elements, running along the lines of intentional givenness, works better for conceptualizing how meaning and predication can emerge from practices than Dreyfus' quasi-naturalist pragmatism can.

2. Non-conceptual and conceptual levels: the incomprehensible break

As we have seen, it is the immersed, unconscious, and non-conceptual response to affordances which, in Dreyfus' eyes, opens up a world in the first place. Arguing along these lines, Dreyfus urges analytic philosophers, working on the "upper stories of the building of knowledge," to unite with phenomenologists who do their work on the "basement" and the "ground floor" (Dreyfus 2005, 63). Although I also welcome a dialogue between analytic philosophy and phenomenology, I think this sort of labor-division is the wrong picture and program to suggest. In fact, the simplistic distinction between "phenomenologists" and "conceptualists" already shows that the debate runs along dichotomies that reinforce the old gap between an unconscious body (providing non-conceptual content) and a conceptualizing mind (providing conceptual content), which especially in Dreyfus' account is reduced to "self-monitoring." This brings about serious problems for Dreyfus as how to make plausible how rationality, or, a space of reasons, could ever grow out of the non-conceptual, mindless sphere of "coping." Dreyfus (2005, 60) vehemently refuses that there might be any implicit conceptual (i.e. reason-giving) structures in our involved experience. I suppose, the reason for this is that, on the one hand, he wants to claim the irreducible importance of the body against the "rationalist tradition" (Dreyfus 2005, 60), and that, on the other hand, such a tradition might again result in cognitivist brain models. His counter-argument against the Kantian/McDowellian picture of an implicit conceptuality running through our perception is thus again an alternative brain-model, for which his phenomenology would provide indication:

"But all we have a right to conclude from our phenomenology of expertise is that there must be some detectable invariant features in what J. J. Gibson calls the ambient optic array and that human beings and animals can learn to respond to them. *These features, although available to the perceptual system, needn't be available to the mind.*" (Dreyfus 2005, 54)⁴

It is a shame that Dreyfus can only see the alternative as ranging between either the adoption of a Kantian picture of "conceptuality all the way through" or the endorsement of the ultimately naturalist view of an unconsciously coping brain, where phenomenology may present a third possible way to address the problem. Let me first shortly depict his take on the "transition-problem"—the transition from mindless coping to a rational grip on the

⁴ In order to explain a little bit more how this model avoids conceptuality, I also quote the subsequent paragraph here: "We can understand this inaccessibility if we consider the way simulated neural networks can be programmed to produce reliable responses. For example, nets have been programmed to distinguish sonar echoes from mines from those from rocks. Such nets are given no rules, nor are they told what features of the signal are relevant. They are simply exposed to tens of thousands of examples and their at-first-random correct responses are reinforced." (Dreyfus 2005, 54)

world—and then, in the last part of this paper, characterize the alternative take on the problem given by Husserl and Heidegger (including a very short look at Merleau-Ponty at the end).

Typically, for Dreyfus this problem is formulated as a rather dramatic break with an unproblematic immersion and automaticity. If this break happens, all of a sudden, the world is “there,” things are “there,” but they are apprehended from a distance, strangely removed from my dealings with them, and *only* thanks to this, they are “objectively there.”⁵ Thus, to explain the sheer givenness of objects, Dreyfus has to point to a specific “skill” he calls “analytic attention” that, in a rather mysterious leap, “brings about a radical transformation of the affordances given to absorbed coping. Only then can we have an experience of objects with properties, about which we can form beliefs, make judgments, and justify inferences” (Dreyfus 2005, 61).

This new state of mind totally wipes out our pre-predicative immersion. Hence, it seems that either we dwell in a dark, blind, and mute immersion or we are homunculi-like spectators looking at the distant world from an “ego tunnel.”⁶ One could certainly ask oneself how “pragmatist” this layout really is. Furthermore, Dreyfus himself admits that this account is not very convincing as far as demonstrating how reasons actually come into this world—and quickly projects this problem (which is his very own) on the whole phenomenological tradition: “Phenomenologists lack a detailed and convincing account of how rationality and language grow out of nonconceptual and nonlinguistic coping.” (Dreyfus 2005, 61)

I not only think that the phenomenological tradition does not have this difficulty—because an account of intentionality involves passive and active elements, and not a leap from the unconscious to the detached; it also does not run into the danger of re-activating another “myth of the given” which founds all other knowledge—because “the given” in phenomenology is always intentionally given and thus, apprehended, however not necessarily by concepts. Dreyfus (2007b, 377), by contrast, is aware that his conception of “mindless coping” might again suggest such a fundament of the “given” which is why he proposes to think through also a possible “horizontal dependency” of his dichotomic spheres, instead of a “ground-floor/upper-story dependency relation.”

3. Non-conceptual and conceptual levels: connected through intentionality

When Dreyfus (2005, 61) complains that there is a “lack of any worked out step-by-step genesis of the conceptual categories that structure the space of reasons from the perceptual ones that structure the space of motivations” one wonders what he takes Husserl’s *Experience and Judgment* (Husserl 1985/1973) to be about. Like in his lectures *Analysen zur passiven Synthesis* (Husserl 1966), in this book Husserl carefully demonstrates, by a genetic account, that predication and its modalities emerge from a pre-predicative sphere, where affection, association, and passive motivation build up a field of meaning. This has nothing to do with

⁵ One of the most drastic illustrative examples Dreyfus gives for his theory is the story of Chuck Knoblauch, a professional baseball player, who somehow suddenly started reflecting on his skills and then never found the way back to his form (cf. Dreyfus 2007a, 354).

⁶ This is exactly what Zahavi calls “the Myth of the Spectatorial Subject.” Cf. also Thomas Fuchs’ (2015) paper “Wege aus dem Ego-Tunnel,” where he quotes and criticizes Thomas Metzinger’s theory of perceiving the world only through an “ego tunnel.”

mental (or even conceptual) representations.⁷ On the contrary, what Husserl opened up with his notion of intentionality was to finally dispense with the idea that there is a representation in the mind which somehow relates to the “outside”; instead, “[b]y intentionality we do not mean an objective relation which occasionally and subsequently takes place between a physical thing and a psychic process, but the structure of a comportment as comporting to, directing itself toward”—as Heidegger (1985, 37) puts it, presenting Husserl’s position affirmingly. Hence, it is experience itself and its structure which is investigated, where experiencing is always a certain actualization of “living-through,” in which something is disclosed, or “given”: the experienced. Phenomenology’s main claim, from Husserl until today, is that *it is this very structure of experience that opens up a world*—even if there might be disputes about how exactly this comes about. But what is undisputed is that this openness, this intentionality, this being a “there,” this being a bodily immersion of “thereness” and “orientedness,” stands in sharp contrast to any non-conscious/non-intentional (i.e. causal or functional) relations. In these relations, nothing is “disclosed,” or “given,” or “meaningful” or even affordance-like, but there are only blind natural forces that are not in need of any space of meaning or motivation at all.⁸

It is surprising that such a fond reader of Heidegger like Dreyfus would not acknowledge Heidegger’s appraisal of Husserl’s “fundamental discovery,” as carried out in the *History of the Concept of Time*, where Heidegger also perceptively defends Husserl’s notion of intentionality against representationalist, cognitivist, and naturalist misunderstandings (cf. Heidegger 1985, 30; 32-36). To be sure, Heidegger dynamizes the intentional relation and radicalizes it, as can be closely observed in §15 of the *Basic Problems of Phenomenology*. Here, Heidegger states that the earlier characterizations of intentionality are somehow “inadequate and external” (Heidegger 1988, 161) given that Dasein transposes itself into its worldly activities, “losing” itself in them, and understanding itself by starting out from this pre-reflective worldly, engaged immersion (cf. 160). It is important to note that this radicalized version of intentionality which Heidegger calls “transcending” or “transcendence,” or “transposition,” or, simply, “being in the world,” is always concomitantly a form of self-awareness: “as the Dasein gives itself over immediately and passionately to the world itself,

⁷ Least of all, intentionality in Husserl means that there is “some content in our minds—some internal representation—that enables us to direct our minds toward each object” (Dreyfus 1991, 5). There are few authors who have criticized and rejected representationalism as adamantly as Husserl—n.b. in his published and most famous works (Husserl 1975, 436-40; Husserl 1976, §43). It seems that Dreyfus is often attacking Husserl when he actually wants to criticize John Searle. Furthermore, as Plotka (xxxx, xx) also shows in his paper, Dreyfus is influenced by the so-called “West Coast” interpretation of the noema, which leads him to the utterly wrong view that Husserl would be a representationalist.

⁸ For that reason, it is quite incomprehensible how Dreyfus (2005, 57) can speak of “motivation” (as well as of a “space of meaning”) without first-personal-givenness. Husserl explicitly opposes “motivation” (be it on an active or passive level) to causal relations (Husserl 1952, 231) (and it is not only Merleau-Ponty but already Husserl who develops a whole phenomenology of motivation). To be motivated without any basic awareness of anything would indeed be quite difficult to imagine—or, rather, it would be more apt to speak of a causal relation if I am just blindly set in motion by something I do not experience. The sphere of passivity, however, is not a blind sphere, but a sphere of emerging consciousness and only here “motivation” in the true sense can occur. I think it is crucial to recognize that a primary space of meaning can only emerge because there is something like awareness. Furthermore, I believe that one can only understand what a “space of meaning” is supposed to be if one recognizes that neither meaning, nor reasons, nor information simply take place like natural occurrences, but that they presuppose an awareness that takes them or experiences them *as* meaning, reasons, or information: i.e. consciousness in its basic feature of intentionality.

its own self is reflected to it from things" (Heidegger 1988, 159). Certainly, we are neither talking about a monitoring self here (which Heidegger explicitly rules out, 158), nor about conceptuality; but simply about a dynamized form of intentionality, i.e. of experiencing something in its thereness and experiencing oneself in living-through this experience. This dynamized notion of intentionality is one that is "ahead of itself," "in the world," "alongside the things it cares for." For Heidegger, this amounts to the pre-predicative sphere of *Seinsverständnis*, the actualizations of which he calls the "hermeneutic as" which is foundational for the apophantic logos stating present-at-handness in judgments. I will come back to this later.

Let us first turn to the more general conception of how phenomenology connects the levels of the non-conceptual and the conceptual. The answer is that this transition is spelled out as intentionalities and their correlates building on one another. As Heidegger also emphasizes: "*The relations between intentionalities are themselves intentional.*" (Heidegger 1985, 33) Hence, the transition is one within the realm of intentional givenness, and not a leap from one dichotomic category, the "unconscious, non-conceptual body" to the other, the "conscious, conceptual mind." Furthermore, it is neither "conceptuality all the way through" (McDowell's solution) which enables a normative grip on the world, nor is it a leap from a blind automaticity to a spectatorial gaze (Dreyfus' picture). Rather, *conceptuality evolves and is rooted in the intentional relationship to the world* (which can be spelled out with different points of emphasis in the phenomenological tradition).

There is a "static" and a "genetic" version to that theory. While the genetic version, presented in *Experience and Judgment*, gives an account of how the categorial forms of predication (and thus of logic: "S is p," negation, conjunction, subsumption etc.) can be traced back to pre-predicative intentionalities in perception, the "static" version dates back much earlier to the *Logical Investigations*. Here, Husserl is not looking for a *Genealogy of Logic* (which is the subtitle of *Experience and Judgment*), but asking how categorial forms can be "given" at all. What is intuitively given in perception is, for example, the white paper, but neither the "whiteness" of the paper, nor the predication/state of affairs "the paper is white." Hence, categorial forms are not intuitively given in the intentional act of perception. Now, Husserl's answer is that there is another form of intentionality, "categorial intuition," which builds on the perceptual one—and this sort of intentionality also has a correlate: the categorial form that is "given" in this act. Starting from what is given in "simple perception" (*schlichte Wahrnehmung*), the white paper, a more complex act can be directed, for example, at the "whiteness" of the paper, or on the predicate of "white" connected to the subject "paper" by the conjunction "is," and it is fulfilled in the categorial intuitions of the respective categorial and predicative structures. Concepts are thus not provided somehow by the "mind" which thereby forms the "world," but they are "disclosed" in intentional acts as the structures of Being.

It is hence not very surprising that for Heidegger this theory of the "categorial intuition" is of utmost importance. Next to intentionality he calls it the "second fundamental discovery of phenomenology" (Heidegger 1985, 47).⁹ Again, the explanation is that a specific type of intentional act—the categorial act—is founded on perceptual givenness. The specific intentionality of this act, intending categorial relations like "and," "or," or state of affairs like the "being red" of a cup, or the "being brighter" of one fabric in comparison with the other,

⁹ I have discussed the topic of categorial intuition in the work of Husserl and Heidegger more closely in the context of transcendental philosophy in the paper Loidolt 2014.

discloses the respective correlates within the given itself. What Heidegger especially appreciates in this account is that it does not employ a Kantian or Neo-Kantian picture of concepts “forming” a given matter. Rather, the categorial forms are *disclosed* by categorial acts, and this disclosure is founded on simple perception, without being reducible to it:

“The categorial ‘forms’ are not constructs of acts but objects which manifest themselves in these acts. They are not something made by the subject and even less something added to the real objects, such that the real entity is itself modified by this forming. Rather, they actually present the entity more truly in its ‘being-in-itself.’” (Heidegger 1985, 70)

And here Heidegger very distinctly, in contrast to all of Dreyfus’ claims, speaks of an implicitness of categorial structures which are “accentuated” and made explicit by categorial intuition: Simple perception, in his words “is already intrinsically pervaded by categorial intuition” and although it is “in fact simple and straightforward,” this does “not rule out a high degree of complexity in its act-structure” (Heidegger 1985, 60).

“In the simple perception of an entity, the perceived entity itself is first there simply [in ‘onefold,’ as it were] without complication. This simplicity means that the real parts and moments included in it do not stand out in relief. But inasmuch as they are present in the unity of the whole object which is apprehended simply, they can also be brought out explicitly. This bringing into relief takes place in new and special acts of explication.” (Heidegger 1985, 63)

Furthermore, to demonstrate that the picture of an unconscious emergence of world that Dreyfus is presenting is not exactly Heidegger’s view, Heidegger never says that things would not be “present” to us when showing themselves to us primarily and for the most part: “Sitting here in the auditorium we do not in fact apprehend walls—not unless we are getting bored. Nevertheless, the walls are already present even before we think them as objects.” (Heidegger 1988, 163)

Would this lead to thinking now that Heidegger is also a cognitivist because he emphasizes is that there is a “simple presence” of the auditorium-walls which is a conscious presence and not an unconscious coping? Does it mean that he operates with tacit rules and a “holistic network of intentional states” (Dreyfus 1991, 5), just because he emphasizes that the object “becomes expressly visible precisely in what it is [...] through this new objectivity of the accentuated state of affairs [in categorial intuition]” (Heidegger 1985, 63)? I obviously do not think that this is a necessary implication, just as it is not so with Husserl. And I think that Heidegger is quite right with granting an implicit complexity to simple perception which can be accentuated and explicated categorically. Moreover, we should not forget that for Heidegger, Husserl’s categorial intuition was one of the keys to posing the question of Being, which is why he calls it one of the “fundamental discoveries”: It targets a fundamental form of understanding that goes beyond the perception of realities and grasps their “ideal” (i.e. non-real, non-perceptual) relations of Being (Heidegger 1985, 63).

Let us now shortly return again to Husserl and to the genetic version of a transition from the pre-predicative to the predicative level. In genetic phenomenology, which Husserl starts to develop around 1918, the “passive sphere” plays an important role. The thematization of the realm of passivity does justice to the fact that conscious life does not only consist of “acts”

like thinking, singing, or willing. Just as much, we are “affected” by and “drawn to” something, and associations “carry us” to certain apprehensions instead of us willingly aiming at them. But all of this does not mean that we would thereby suddenly enter the sphere of the “unconscious” or subconscious. Passivity is just something we do not actively “do,” but still, we experience it. Consider, for example, inner time-consciousness which is the most basic passive accomplishment and which is certainly experienced in the flow of “living through” (or simply, be hearing a melody), even though it is not focused or reflected on, and certainly not actively intended. Complementarily, the “pre-givenness” (*Vorgegebenheit*) of the world is “there” for us without “making” it, but is still built up in its sense by passive accomplishments. This is the main theme of *Experience and Judgment*: How is a field of pre-givenness experienced, i.e. intentionally “given,” and how do the predicative activities of consciousness rest on these pre-predicative accomplishments?

It is important to note that the spheres of “passivity” and “activity” do not coincide with the “pre-predicative” and the “predicative” sphere. To the contrary, activity is already to be found in the pre-predicative sphere, which again avoids a split up in two dichotomic levels having nothing to do with each other. In the pre-predicative sphere, Husserl demonstrates how, by the forces of affection and association, something from the background moves to the foreground and becomes further explored, generating an accumulation of meaning, orientedness, and disclosedness, but not yet (predicative) knowledge about the perceived environment. He starts out with a passively immersed self, which is “woken” to attention and further acts by an “affective force.” The attention that is awakened by this affection emerging from the field of passive pre-givenness cannot be described as “detached” at all. Rather, we are talking about “receptivity as the most basic form of activity” in perception (Husserl 1973, §17)—a theme that Merleau-Ponty draws on widely—which is closely linked to the process of bodily, kinaesthetic perception itself. Husserl’s point is precisely that in pre-predicative perception such a detachment is not possible; only after the accomplishment of predication has happened, which generates forms of objectivity as its correlates, can these forms be separated from the direct, immersed process of perception (cf. Husserl 1973, 198). Consequently, pre-predicative perception does not have “objects” yet, but only continuing sequences of perception on which it follows and which it partly guides, again attracted by affective forces. It is in this context, where the term “horizon” (which I mentioned at the beginning) becomes relevant.

With the perceptually given, its horizons are also “awakened” (Husserl 1973, 82), meaning possible directions of exploration which the exploring perceiver can follow or not and which she will follow, pulled again by certain “tendencies,” which are passively experienced affective forces. Neither does the horizontal structure suddenly create relevance (as Dreyfus seems to suspect), nor do horizons “frame” anything. Rather, they make up the already meaningful, intentional givenness of something, which is never a context-free, singled-out objectivity, but always embedded in spatial, temporal, inner and outer horizons. Furthermore, what Husserl always emphasizes is that consciousness is never a mode of total attention, but always and essentially surrounded by an experiential background, or corona. Of course, attention can shift and wander, putting one feature in actuality while the other slides back into inactuality; but as a general characteristic of consciousness, the background, diffusing into a certain darkness from where affections can again emerge, can never be made fully explicit (as Dreyfus [1995, 5f.] suggests, again having a cognitivist picture in mind). In *Experience and Judgment*, Husserl speaks of “*Ichhintergrund*” (background of the ego) and “*Ichgegenüber*” (confronting the ego) as well as of “*Hintergrunderlebnis*” (background-

experience) and “*Vordergrunderlebnis*” (foreground-experience) (Husserl 1985, 81/ Husserl 1973, 77).

The stage of predication, finally, builds on these pre-predicatively constituted meanings and actively objectifies them. And again, like in the case of “categorical intuition,” we are speaking about purely inner-intentional relations here. All terms of affection in the pre-predicative sphere have to be understood intentionally and not causally, which means that they are gradually rising forms of consciousness which emerge from an already shaped field of meaning (which is also conscious, however not conceptually conceived, but instead only associatively and affectively structured). Predicative acts intentionally build on this perceptual and bodily basis of sense, habitualization and sedimentation, grasping predicative structures by actively intending them. The predicative sphere can hence be identified with disclosing the categorial and conceiving it in a new, abstract form as “concepts.” However, Husserl certainly does not mean by this, as Dreyfus (1995, 5f.) again suggests, that there would be something like “tacit knowledge” in the pre-predicative sphere, generated by “tacit rules.” Rather, again intentional relations *build on one another*, spontaneously disclose categorial forms as the correlates of judgments, and constitute them as new, abstract objectivities, detached from the concrete perception. This is important in order to comprehend how intentionality—and not conceptuality—leads from motivational, passive to active, categorial structures:

“Thus it is a matter here of objectifying achievements of a new kind, not merely of an activity attached to the pre-given and receptively apprehended objects; rather in predicative knowledge and its deposit [*Niederschlag*] in the predicative judgment new kinds of objectivities are constituted, which can then themselves be apprehending again and be made thematic as logical structures, i.e. as what we call *categorial objectivities*, since they arise from the *kategorieren*, the act of declarative judgment [...]. Thus the work of cognition, this higher stage of activity, must, in contrast to receptivity, be characterized as a *creative spontaneity*, itself already productive of objects.” (Husserl 1973, 198f.)

To repeat it again: What we find in *Experience in Judgment* is not a leap from a blind automaticity to a spectatorial gaze, but a worked out genesis that demonstrates how conceptuality evolves and is rooted in the intentional relationship to the world: a relationship of passive and bodily immersion, shaped by affection and association, by the horizon-structure, and by receptivity as the most basic form of activity. The story Husserl tells, leading from the pre-predicative to the predicative sphere, can certainly not hastily be equated with Heidegger’s transition from the “hermeneutic” to the “apophantic as.” Let me therefore, to complete the argument, turn to Heidegger’s existential reformulation of the topic in the conceptual pair of the “hermeneutical” and the “apophantic as.” Also here, the transition is not simply to be framed as a transition from the “practically immersed” to the “theoretically detached.” To be sure, Heidegger emphasizes that by the *logos apophantikos* “our seeing gets *restricted*” and that only “by this explicit *restriction* [*Einschränkung*] of our view, that which is already manifest may be made *explicitly* manifest in its definite character [*um das Offenbare in seiner Bestimmtheit ausdrücklich offenbar zu machen*].” (Heidegger 1967, 155; Heidegger 1962, 197)

In these passages of *Being and Time*, Heidegger lays out that understanding is an equiprimordial existentiale (like affectedness [*Befindlichkeit*] and discourse [*Rede*]), which characterizes the disclosedness of our Being-in-the-world. Features that could be called

pragmatist are obvious here: Heidegger phenomenologically describes how existential understanding has always already opened up a meaningful space whose significance correlates to possibilities of Dasein and its constant temporal being-ahead-of-itself in projections: “The innerworldly being is projected upon a world—that is, upon a whole of significance, in whose reference-relations care, as Being-in-the-world, has manifested itself beforehand.” (Heidegger 1962: 192, trans.mod.) Heidegger insists that these are not theoretical judgments, but practical possibilities, and that meaning is originally constituted only by this practical involvement. Any theoretical judgment has to build on the structure of existential understanding, including fore-having, fore-sight, fore-conception (*Vorhabe, Vorsicht, Vorgriff*). At the same time, it effectively narrows down the scope to predication only. This is why the “apophantic as” is presented as resulting from a restriction, whereas the “hermeneutic as” is the original openness and disclosedness of possibilities. Insofar as this openness is a practical one where the “in order to” (of ready-to-handness) corresponds to the “for the sake of which” of Dasein, Dreyfus (1991, 84) is right that “[f]or Heidegger primordial understanding is know-how.” It is also correct that there is a fundamental dispute between Husserl and Heidegger concerning the primary mode of object- and world-givenness. But to assess this dispute, it is important to understand that Husserl is interested in layers of constitution (how meaning is “built up”), whereas Heidegger is interested in the origin of meaning or significance. Husserl would never deny that the practical world is immediately present to us, that we immediately see tables, books, pianos, and friends (Husserl 1976, §27).¹⁰ But he wants to know what the different layers are that make up this givenness, down to the most basic syntheses of time-consciousness, knowing that these layers only present themselves to us in an *analysis* of perception. Heidegger calls this the “primacy of the theoretical” and argues that the origin of significance can never be drawn from such a layer-model. Rather, it has to be understood by starting out from Dasein’s way of Being which *is* transcending, and thus not an intentional act, but being immersed in a world, being opened up to a world, and not “constituting” it.

Without disputing this conflict, I would, finally, like to point to three issues that might nevertheless suggest that the pragmatism Heidegger is heading for is different than the version of pragmatism that Dreyfus is suggesting, drawing unavoidably near to naturalism: First, in the quote above, Heidegger speaks of “that which is already manifest” as that which is then made explicit in the “apophantic as.” This implies that there is a disclosedness in the existential, primordial understanding of the “hermeneutic as” which cannot be “unconscious.” Dreyfus, by contrast, repeatedly claims that this sort of “understanding” is a simple response to the solicitations of the situation and that “the brain can handle that without thought” (Dreyfus 1991, 187). I hope to have made clear that phenomenologists

¹⁰ It is therefore misleading if Dreyfus (1991, 197) writes that for Husserl “[s]eeing a ‘mere physical thing,’ [...] is basic (*Cartesian Meditations*, 78).” First of all, the original speaks of a “bloßes daseiendes Ding” (a merely existing thing) which we encounter in everyday life (Husserl 1950, 112); to see “physical things” requires quite some layers of intentional accomplishment. But, most importantly, Husserl is in the middle of a genetic analysis here, trying to show that even this primitive givenness of a plain thing points to constitutional layers of passive synthesis and that this synthesis also has a history. In early childhood, Husserl continues, there is nothing which could yet be explicated as a “thing” by mere perception. Such accomplishments thus have to be built up, and intersubjectivity plays an important role in this process. In fact, this could be a point of interest for Dreyfus who explicitly points to the importance of developmental questions, given that the “organism starts Daseining gradually” (Dreyfus 1991, 187).

never mean “thought” as a predicative act when they talk about basic and passive forms of intentionality—but they do mean a special sort of awareness. Were this not the case, there would be no “as” at all. This insight should also shift the debate from only looking at the “content” of experience, i.e. only at the *what* and not at the *how* of experience. To put all the weight, concerning the question as to whether or not experience itself can hold reasons or meaning, exclusively on content (be it conceptual or non-conceptual), not only prolongs what Heidegger called the problematic (Neo-)Kantian picture of a subject forming an unformed matter. It also ignores the phenomenological insight that no matter how structured, how conceptually loaded some “content” is, if it is not consciously taken up *as* something—directly in experiencing—it remains as meaningless as a patterned carpet by itself. By this I mean: For something to be a token of information, it is not enough that it simply be structured; there must be a conscious relation to it that takes it *as* something. This as-relation simply resists naturalization because there is no meaningful “as” in naturalist terms (a functional “as” is not an experienced “as,” but rather it is this experience that is reinterpreted into a function). Phenomenology thus urges us to look at the *how* of experience, i.e. how it is *lived through*. Therefore, I would advocate that a shift from one intentionality to the other (as explained above) is a much more plausible explanation for the different modes of the “hermeneutic” and “apophantic” than a leap from the unconscious to the consciously detached.

Second: That ready-to-handness is the primary mode by which we encounter the world stands as an ontological claim for Heidegger, and along the lines of the project of *Being and Time*, this is equivalent to being a transcendental claim.¹¹ This means that the structure of Dasein qua Being-in-the-world is the primary, un-circumventable, and irreducible structure from which all meaning originates. Everything we can possibly say about Being and beings is rooted in this structure, which is why Heidegger calls his project “fundamental ontology.” Thus, I would class Heidegger’s pragmatism as being of the transcendental variety more than anything else.

Third: I agree that it is right to say that understanding in Heidegger is primarily to be conceived as “knowing how” and not as “knowing that.” But this should not lead us to think that understanding is only handling tools, playing chess or baseball, cooking, or running after the streetcar. Essentially, Heidegger claims that we always already have an *understanding of Being*, no matter how dark, how mistaken, how inexplicit this is. It *can* only be mistaken because it is a form of awareness of ourselves and the world. The “hermeneutical as” is thus in itself a certain understanding of Being and, simultaneously, a certain form of self-disclosure instead of a mindless state of immersion. I doubt that we can even get near to what Heidegger calls an understanding of Being if we continue thinking about ourselves as embodied brains that happen to have this or that perceptual structure.

Finally, without being able to demonstrate this here, I also believe that Merleau-Ponty’s ontology does not allow for such a short circuit. Merleau-Ponty’s concept of “motor intentionality” needs to be examined precisely in its *intentional* character, i.e. as a form of (conscious) givenness of a space of meaning that also invites virtual and theoretical activity. With the passive, basic, bodily forms of intentionality that Merleau-Ponty describes, he explicitly refers to the Husserlian concept of “operating intentionality” (*fungierende Intentionalität*), which allows for subversion of the dichotomy between practical immersion and mindful detachedness. As I hope to have made clear, the phenomenological notion of

¹¹ With this interpretation I also relate to Steven Crowell’s work on Heidegger, emphasizing the importance of the transcendental element in *Being and Time* (cf. Crowell 2001, Crowell/Malpas 2007).

intentionality is not to be reduced to being a “mental state.” The “body” is therefore not the opposite of the “mind” and the “theoretical,” but it is the *lived bodily experience* that lies beyond this Cartesian picture. The central concern of Merleau-Ponty is looking for a new transcendental approach guided by this phenomenological insight to overcome empiricism and intellectualism, which finally leads him to establish a new ontology in his late work.¹² Similarly for Heidegger, it is the question of Being that guides all his phenomenological inquiries. I believe that the pragmatist elements are important in the work of Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty and that they constitute an important development in spelling out the mind-world-relation in the phenomenological tradition. But I also think that this should be understood as a specifically phenomenological version of pragmatism which is and remains guided by an idea of intentionality in its different forms, resisting dichotomies and, eventually, naturalization.

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¹² As Jakub Čapek (xxxx) shows in his paper appearing in this volume, a major element in this late ontology is “perceptual faith,” which must be considered as the most basic form of world-encounter that lies beyond practical involvement and thus also beyond a dichotomy of the “practical” versus the “theoretical.”

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